FORGING A NEW PATH

HOW BRICS+ INITIATIVES ARE BUILDING A MORE INCLUSIVE GLOBAL DEVELOPMENT MODEL

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For decades, the architecture of global development has been dominated by a Western-led consensus. Institutions such as the International Monetary Fund (IMF), the World Bank, and the OECD have established the terms of engagement, designing a system intended to promote growth and stability. Yet, for vast swathes of the Global South, the track record of this system reveals not triumph, but persistent structural failure. The limitations of this old model have spurred a search for alternatives, and the expansion of the BRICS+ bloc represents the most significant institutional response to this demand. It is evolving from a political dialogue forum into a platform actively operationalising a different development philosophy – one

built not on abstract ideals but on a growing portfolio of specific initiatives aimed at achieving more equitable and sovereign growth.

The failures of the traditional model are threefold. First, the architecture of global finance is fundamentally exclusionary. Voting power in institutions like the IMF and World Bank remains a privilege of wealth, not a right of representation. This entrenches a democratic deficit at the heart of global governance, leaving emerging economies with minimal influence over the very policies that dictate their economic fate. Second, the lifeline of development finance comes with paralysing strings attached. Loans from traditional lenders are often conditioned on austerity measures, privatisation, and trade liberalisation. These prescriptions often undermine national sovereignty, force cuts to vital public services, and exacerbate inequality — prioritising debt repayment over human dignity. Third, the model itself prioritises abstract metrics over tangible human outcomes. Development projects are often export-oriented and infrastructure-heavy, designed for efficiency on a spreadsheet rather than resilience in a community. This approach, coupled with fragmented and volatile aid flows, makes long-term, locally-owned planning nearly impossible.

To assess the credibility of the BRICS+ alternative, one must move beyond summit declarations and examine the machinery on the ground. Its approach to inclusive development is being advanced through two primary, interconnected channels: targeted project financing and a broader ecosystem deliberately designed to enhance economic sovereignty.

The project-first mandate: The NDB in action

The most tangible instrument of the BRICS+ vision is the New Development Bank (NDB). Conceived as a direct counterpoint to traditional multilateral banks, its operational mandate focuses squarely on funding sustainable infrastructure projects that address foundational bottlenecks to economic participation. A review of its portfolio, particularly in Africa, reveals a strategic emphasis on energy, water, and transport –sectors that are the bedrock of broad-based growth.

This project-based approach is not theoretical; it is visible in concrete initiatives across the continent. South Africa's just energy transition, supported by a $480 million NDB loan for renewable energy generation and grid infrastructure, directly addresses the country's severe "load-shedding" crisis, which has crippled small businesses and compromised public services. By focusing on energy stability – a fundamental prerequisite for any economic activity – the project strengthens the grassroots economy and provides a tangible foundation for inclusive growth.

The Lesotho Highlands Water Project Phase II, backed by a $150 million loan to co-finance the Polihali Dam, exemplifies a model of regional development structured for mutual benefit. It provides Lesotho with vital royalties and hydropower while securing a critical water supply for South Africa's industrial heartland, moving beyond extractive paradigms toward integrated, shared prosperity.

Similarly, Egypt's solar power generation initiative, involving a $500 million loan for the 500 MW Kom Ombo solar plant – one of the largest private-sector utility-scale solar plants in the country – supports Egypt's national goal of sourcing 42% of its energy from renewables by 2030. By adding substantial clean capacity to the national grid, it helps meet the growing energy demands of both industry and households, contributing to price stability and expanding access – a key element of long-term, inclusive economic planning.

Beyond individual projects, the NDB's strategic engagement signals a deeper alignment with continental ambitions. Its potential role in financing transformative regional corridors, such as Kenya's LAPSSET project or the Abidjan-Lagos Highway, is pivotal for the success of the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA). By facilitating the movement of goods and services, such investments stimulate intra-African trade and create cross-border economic opportunities that are the lifeblood of endogenous development.



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